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Thelma Rawlings, wife of a Kansas cattleman, was in Florida Monday to collect her sweepstakes prize — a 2.5-acre island with a sprawling custom-built Gulf coast home.

Persistent wife wins an island

INVERNESS, Fla. (AP) — Thelma Rawlings, wife of a Kansas cattleman, put up her rifle, left her century-old farmhouse in Eureka and came to Florida on Monday to collect a prize — her own island in the sun.

For the price of a stamp, the 50-year-old grandmother won a 2.5-acre tree-shaded homestead with a sprawling custom-built house, 1,000 feet of shoreline and two boats on Florida's Central Gulf Coast.

The choice was hers — \$100,000 or the private, picturesque retreat as first-place winner among 2 million entrants in a sweepstakes sponsored by a tobacco company.

Having a modern luxury house had been a long-time dream for Mrs. Rawlings. The perennial contest entrant had been trying to win a house for nearly 20 years. Paging through an outdoors magazine last summer she clipped a coupon and mailed it.

"I've cried, cussed, kicked, screamed and fought for a house. But farm people just don't go out and buy houses," she said.

Mrs. Rawlings has spent much of her time patching up the 100-year-old, two-story Kansas farmhouse where she lives with her husband Raymond. "I paneled, put in ceilings, floors, rugs, a patio — the only thing I haven't moved at our place is the house," she said.

Mrs. Rawlings said her husband didn't put much stock in contests. When she first told him she won an island, he just shrugged. But when he realized it was for real, "he cried," she said.

The couple flew to Florida two weeks ago for a first glimpse of their property.

Winning isn't anything new to Mrs. Rawlings, a licensed beautician who in her spare time breeds Brittany spaniels, raises and cans all her own vegetables and fruits, hunts, fishes and paints.

In 1953 she won on the "Queen for a Day" television show. Another time she guessed the number of marbles in a jar and won a washing machine.

"It's not luck," she insisted. "It's that I believe."

Would she be bored trading the wide open spaces for a hideaway in a retirement area? "I think the only way to be bored is to be dead," she replied.

A short causeway links the island with the mainland. Nestled among the hickory and cypress is an eight-room wood-frame home that took former Orlando builder Stanley Hoffman nearly two years to construct.

A spokesman for the contest sponsor, Brown and Williamson, said the tobacco firm purchased the estate for nearly \$300,000.

The Rawlings won't be moving in before winter, although Mrs. Rawlings was given the keys Monday. "Quail season is just about to start," she said. "I don't want to miss it. I can shoot a rifle as well as any man — whether squirrel, dove or chicken prairie."

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